

A RESOURCE FOR BUSINESSES



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INFORMED. INSPIRED. CONNECTED.

SEPTEMBER EDITION

Momentum for the Season Ahead:

Agentic AI, the relevance economy and a financial-resilience playbook



Business Link
Media Group

PUBLISHER'S NOTE

Dear Business Link Readers,

As summer gives way to the busiest stretch of the business calendar, this edition of *Business Link* turns its attention to momentum — the steps organizations take now to finish the year strong and enter 2027 on solid ground. Across technology, health, and finance, the through-line is the same: the companies that prepare deliberately in the fourth quarter tend to be the ones with the most options in the first.

INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY

We look at how “agentic” artificial intelligence is moving from demonstration to day-to-day operations, what on-device AI means for privacy-conscious businesses, and why practical cybersecurity has become a core responsibility for even the smallest teams. Together these stories show technology maturing into infrastructure rather than novelty.

HEALTH & WORKFORCE

Preventive health is increasingly a business strategy, not only a personal one. We examine the growing “longevity economy,” the return on workplace wellness spending, and how employers are rebuilding mental-health support for a workforce that is still adjusting to hybrid work.

FINANCE & GROWTH

With borrowing costs still elevated by recent standards, we offer a practical playbook for financial resilience, a plain-language look at what the Bank of Canada’s next decisions could mean for your operating line, and five numbers every owner should watch heading into year-end.

AROUND THE REGION

We also spotlight the season ahead in Niagara — from the 75th Niagara Grape & Wine Festival to the Canadian Greenhouse Conference — events that keep the regional economy connected.

We hope these stories give you useful ideas and a little added confidence for the quarter ahead. Happy reading!

Yours in Business
Marilyn Tian, M.B.A
President & Co-Publisher
Business Link Media Group



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BUSINESS & ECONOMIC INSIGHTS

Niagara's Fall Economic Outlook: Confidence, Labour and the Quarter Ahead

The region enters the fourth quarter with steady tourism numbers, a tight but easing labour market, and small-business owners planning cautiously for 2027.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

Every autumn, the Niagara economy runs a familiar relay. The summer visitor season hands off to the wine harvest, the harvest hands off to conference season at the Niagara Falls Convention Centre, and the whole region settles into the stretch of the year when businesses decide how confident they really feel about what comes next. Heading into the fourth quarter of 2026, the mood among local owners can be summed up in a single word: deliberate.

Tourism, still the region's largest employer, has held up. Hotel occupancy across Niagara Falls tracked close to prior-year levels through the summer, and operators report that shoulder-season bookings — September and October weekends built around wine touring, festivals and sporting events — are pacing slightly ahead of last year. The visitor economy is no longer growing at the pace of the immediate post-pandemic rebound, but it has stabilized at a level that supports steady hiring in accommodation, food service and attractions.

The bigger story is labour. For three years, the single most common complaint from Niagara employers was that they could not find enough people. That pressure has eased, though it has not disappeared. Restaurants and hotels report that they are able to fill seasonal roles more easily

than in 2023 or 2024, and wage growth for front-line positions has cooled from the double-digit jumps of that period to something closer to the rate of inflation. Skilled trades, healthcare support and experienced managers remain genuinely hard to hire.

Agriculture and food processing — the economic backbone of the region's rural townships — are entering harvest with cautious optimism. Grape growers expect a solid crop, and the greenhouse sector, concentrated in west Niagara, continues to expand square footage and automate. Energy costs and the price of imported inputs remain the swing factors that determine whether a strong season translates into a strong year.

Small-business sentiment is the part of the picture that deserves the closest reading. Owners are not pulling back, but they are sequencing their decisions. Hiring plans are being staged rather than committed all at once. Equipment purchases are being timed to year-end tax planning. Expansion into a second location is more often being described as a 2027 project than a 2026 one. This is not pessimism; it is the behaviour of operators who have lived through several years of surprises and want to keep their options open.

“ Owners are not pulling back. They are sequencing their decisions — staging hires, timing purchases to year-end, describing expansion as a 2027 project.

BUSINESS & ECONOMIC INSIGHTS

Niagara's Fall Economic Outlook — continued

Credit conditions are a live concern. Business owners who carried variable-rate debt through the high-rate period are watching the Bank of Canada closely, and many have used the past year to refinance, extend terms or build a larger cash buffer. Commercial landlords report that tenants are renewing rather than relocating, prioritizing stability over a slightly better rate somewhere else.

There are tailwinds. Niagara's relative affordability compared with the Greater Toronto Area continues to attract small firms and remote-friendly employers. Public investment in transit and border infrastructure is moving forward. And the region's post-secondary institutions keep feeding graduates into local employers, particularly in health sciences, business and the skilled trades.

Retail and hospitality operators say the composition of spending has shifted. Visitors are still coming, but they are more selective, which rewards operators who can offer a clear value proposition and control costs without cutting the parts of the experience customers actually notice. For professional-services firms, the picture is steadier, and

several report that advisory work has increased as owners seek help with financing, succession and cost control.

Succession is a quiet theme running underneath all of this. A significant share of Niagara's established businesses are owned by people who are now thinking seriously about the next five years. That is creating a steady flow of transactions — sales to employees, sales to strategic buyers, family transfers — and a corresponding need for the advisory, legal and financing infrastructure that supports them.

The practical takeaway for owners is to treat the fourth quarter as a planning quarter. Lock in the financing you will need for 2027 while conditions are known. Have the year-end conversation with your accountant in October, not December. Decide now which roles you will hire in January and start the search early, because the candidates you want are already being courted. The businesses that enter the new year with a written plan, a funded plan and a staffed plan will spend the first quarter executing while their competitors are still deciding.

KEY POINTS

- Tourism has stabilized rather than kept growing; shoulder-season bookings are pacing slightly ahead of last year.
- The labour squeeze has eased for front-line roles but skilled trades, healthcare support and experienced managers stay hard to hire.
- Credit conditions are the live concern — owners are refinancing, extending terms and building cash buffers ahead of renewals.
- Business succession is generating a steady flow of transactions and demand for advisory, legal and financing support.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Treat Q4 as a planning quarter: lock in 2027 financing while conditions are known, hold the year-end tax conversation in October, and start January hiring searches now.

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Agentic AI Goes to Work: What Autonomous Agents Mean for Growing Businesses

The next wave of workplace AI does not just answer questions — it completes multi-step tasks. For small and mid-sized companies, the opportunity is real and so is the need for guardrails.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

For most of the past three years, the business conversation about artificial intelligence has centred on assistants: tools that draft an email, summarize a document or answer a customer's question when a person asks them to. The emerging generation of "agentic" AI is different in an important way. An agent is given a goal, and it plans and carries out the sequence of steps required to reach it — checking data, calling other software, making intermediate decisions and reporting back only when the job is done or when it needs a human to approve something.

In practice, that might look like an agent that monitors incoming invoices, matches each one against the purchase order and delivery record, flags the exceptions and queues the rest for payment. Or one that watches a shared inbox, triages requests, drafts responses in the company's voice and schedules the follow-ups. Or a research agent that assembles a briefing on a prospective client from public sources before a sales call. None of these tasks is glamorous. All of them consume hours that a small team would rather spend elsewhere.

Why now? Three things changed at roughly the same time. The underlying models became reliable enough to chain many steps together without drifting off course.

Software vendors added standard ways for AI to connect securely to calendars, accounting systems, customer records and document stores. And the tools for supervising an agent — seeing what it did, setting limits on what it may do, and requiring sign-off for sensitive actions — matured to the point where a cautious business can actually deploy one.

For growing companies, the appeal is straightforward. Agentic tools promise the leverage of hiring without the fixed cost, and they are most valuable precisely where smaller organizations are stretched thinnest: bookkeeping, scheduling, procurement, first-line customer support, compliance paperwork and data entry between systems that were never designed to talk to each other.

The risks are equally concrete. An agent that can take actions can take wrong actions quickly and at scale. It may misread an instruction, act on stale data, or be manipulated by a cleverly worded email into doing something it should not. It can also create a quiet dependency: if a critical process runs entirely through an agent that no one on staff fully understands, that is an operational vulnerability.

“Treat an AI agent the way you would a capable new hire with no institutional memory: a clear job, useful tools, close supervision at first.”

A sensible way to start is to pick one bounded, rules-heavy, low-stakes process — something where the right answer is usually obvious and a mistake is easily caught and reversed. Keep a human in the approval loop for anything that moves money, sends an external commitment or changes a customer record. Insist on a full log of every action the agent takes. Give it the narrowest possible access to systems and data. And write down, in plain language, what the agent is allowed to do, what it must escalate, and who owns it.

It is also worth being candid with your team. Framed badly, agentic AI reads as a threat. Framed well — as a way to hand the least rewarding parts of a job to software so that people can spend more time on judgment, relationships and problem-solving — it is far more likely to be adopted and improved by the people who use it every day.

There is a cost question that vendors rarely lead with. Agentic tools are typically priced by usage — the number of tasks run, or the volume of work processed — and a

process that looks inexpensive in a pilot can become a meaningful line item at full volume. Before committing, model the monthly cost at realistic scale, and make sure the process you are automating is one where the time saved clearly exceeds what you will pay.

Integration is the other practical hurdle. An agent is only as useful as its access to your systems, and many smaller businesses run a patchwork of tools that were adopted one at a time. The good news is that the effort of connecting those systems for an agent often produces a side benefit: it forces the kind of clean-up and documentation of processes that the business needed anyway.

The technology will keep advancing, and the vendors will keep promising more autonomy than most businesses should grant on day one. The organizations that benefit will be the ones that treat an AI agent the way they would treat a capable new hire with no institutional memory: give it a clear job, useful tools, close supervision at first, and steadily more responsibility as it earns trust.

KEY POINTS

- An agent is given a goal and carries out the multi-step work to reach it, escalating to a person only when needed.
- Guardrails matter — narrow system access, full action logs, and human sign-off for money, external commitments and customer records.
- Best early targets are bounded, rules-heavy tasks: bookkeeping, scheduling, procurement, first-line support, compliance paperwork.
- Model the cost at real volume; usage-based pricing can turn a cheap pilot into a meaningful line item.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Start with one bounded, low-stakes process, keep a human approval step for anything that moves money or touches a customer record, log every action, and expand the agent's responsibility only as it earns trust.

The Quiet Rise of On-Device AI

More AI is running directly on laptops and phones instead of in the cloud. For businesses that handle sensitive information, that shift is worth understanding.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

“Ask vendors a direct question: where exactly is our data processed, and can we require the local option?”

Most of the AI features businesses use today send data to a provider's servers, process it there and send back a result. A growing share of everyday AI now runs locally — on the laptop, phone or office server itself — without the information ever leaving the building.

The change is being driven by hardware. Recent processors include dedicated components for AI work, and the models themselves have become dramatically smaller without losing much capability for common tasks such as transcription, summarization, search across your own files, image cleanup and drafting.

For a business, on-device processing has three practical advantages. The first is privacy: client records, financial details and draft documents can be analyzed without being transmitted to a third party, which simplifies confidentiality obligations and contractual commitments. The second is cost predictability — local processing does

not carry a per-use fee. The third is resilience, because the feature keeps working when the internet does not.

There are trade-offs. The largest, most capable models still run in the cloud, so the most demanding tasks will continue to go there. Managing models across a fleet of computers adds a small IT burden. And “on-device” is a claim worth verifying rather than assuming; some products blend local and cloud processing in ways that are not obvious from the marketing.

The reasonable posture for most organizations is to ask vendors a direct question — where exactly is our data processed, and can we require the local option? — and to route the most sensitive work to tools that can answer it well. On-device AI will not replace the cloud, but for the specific category of confidential, routine work it offers a genuinely better fit.

KEY POINTS

- On-device AI runs on the laptop, phone or office server, so the data never leaves the building.
- Dedicated AI hardware and much smaller models now handle transcription, summarization, file search and drafting locally.
- The gains are privacy, predictable cost and resilience when the internet is down.
- “On-device” is a marketing claim worth verifying — some tools quietly blend local and cloud processing.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Ask every AI vendor where your data is processed and whether you can require the local option, then route confidential, routine work to tools that keep it on the device.

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HEALTH & WORKFORCE

The Longevity Economy: How Preventive Health Became a Business Strategy

Employers are treating employee health as an investment with a measurable return, and a fast-growing sector of companies is selling the tools to manage it.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

The phrase “longevity economy” describes the goods and services built around helping people stay healthy and productive for longer — not just medical care, but preventive screening, nutrition, sleep, fitness, mental health, physiotherapy and the workplace programs that tie them together. It is one of the more durable growth stories in the economy because it rests on two facts that will not change: populations are aging, and the cost of poor health is enormous and largely avoidable.

For employers, the shift in thinking is from health as a benefits-line expense to health as an operational input. Absence, turnover, disability claims and lost focus all have price tags, and they are heavily concentrated in a small number of preventable or manageable conditions — musculoskeletal injury, cardiovascular risk, poorly managed diabetes, anxiety and depression. Money spent early on prevention and support tends to be far cheaper than money spent later on replacement and claims.

That logic has produced a wave of programs. Some are simple and inexpensive: subsidized fitness access, ergonomic assessments, flexible scheduling for appointments, healthier food at meetings, and manager training to spot strain before it becomes leave. Others are more structured, including on-site or virtual primary care,

physiotherapy benefits with low friction to access, biometric screening, and navigation services that help an employee actually get a specialist appointment rather than giving up.

The evidence on return is real but conditional. Programs that are well designed, easy to use, sustained over years and backed by genuine leadership participation show reductions in absence and claims that comfortably exceed their cost. Programs that are one-off wellness challenges, poorly communicated or quietly optional tend to reach the employees who were already healthy and change little. The differentiator is not the size of the budget; it is whether the program is treated as a core part of how the organization operates.

For smaller employers, the barrier is usually capacity rather than money. A twenty-person company cannot run an on-site clinic, but it can choose a benefits plan with strong mental-health and paramedical coverage, remove the administrative hurdles that stop people from using it, schedule around health, and make it normal to talk about. Pooled arrangements through industry associations and chambers of commerce increasingly give small firms access to services that were once the preserve of large employers.

“The differentiator is not the size of the budget; it is whether the program is treated as a core part of how the organization operates.”

HEALTH & WORKFORCE*The Longevity Economy — continued*

There is also a customer-facing side to the trend. Niagara's wellness tourism, its fitness and rehabilitation providers, its greenhouse-grown fresh produce and its food and beverage makers reformulating for health all sit inside the same economy. The demographic wave that makes preventive health a workforce issue also makes it a market.

Technology has lowered the barrier further. Virtual care, app-based physiotherapy guidance, mental-health platforms and simple digital tools that help an employee find and book the right provider have made it possible to offer meaningful support without a physical clinic. The caution is the same one that applies to any benefit: adoption depends on how easy the tool is to start using and whether people trust that their information stays private.

A further shift is toward measuring health at the level of the team rather than the individual. Aggregated, anonymized data on absence patterns, benefit usage and engagement survey results can show an employer where strain is concentrating — a particular department, a particular season, a particular shift pattern — in time to change something. Used carefully and transparently, that turns wellness from a set of optional perks into a management signal.

The practical message for owners is that health spending is worth analyzing with the same rigour as any other investment. Ask what it costs the business when someone is absent, injured or disengaged; direct preventive resources at the conditions that drive those costs; make the good choice the easy choice; and measure results over a multi-year horizon rather than a single quarter.

KEY POINTS

- The costs of poor health concentrate in a few preventable or manageable conditions — musculoskeletal injury, cardiovascular risk, diabetes, anxiety and depression.
- Well-designed, easy-to-use, sustained programs show returns that exceed their cost; one-off wellness challenges rarely do.
- For small employers the barrier is capacity, not money — pooled plans through associations widen access to services once limited to large firms.
- Niagara's wellness tourism, rehab providers and fresh-produce makers all sit inside the same longevity economy.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Analyze health spending like any other investment: price out what absence, injury and disengagement cost you, aim preventive resources at the conditions driving those costs, make the healthy choice the easy one, and measure over years.

HEALTH & WORKFORCE

Workplace Mental Health After the Hybrid Era

Several years into hybrid work, employers are finding that flexibility solved some problems and created others. The response is shifting from perks to structure.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

“The question that matters is whether people feel able to raise a problem before it becomes a leave.”

Hybrid and remote work removed real sources of stress — long commutes, rigid hours, the difficulty of managing appointments and family around a fixed office day. It also introduced new ones. Boundaries between work and home blur. Newer employees miss the informal learning and belonging that come from being around colleagues. Managers have less visibility into how their people are actually doing, and isolation can build quietly.

Employers that have adapted well share a few habits. They are explicit about expectations — which hours overlap, how fast a message needs a reply, when cameras matter and when they do not — so that ambiguity does not become a low-grade stressor. They protect focus time and discourage the after-hours creep that hybrid work makes easy. And they design deliberate in-person moments for the things that genuinely need them: onboarding, mentoring, planning and celebration.

On mental health specifically, the trend is away from standalone perks and toward making support routine and easy to reach. That means benefits plans with meaningful counselling coverage and short waits, employee assistance programs that people actually remember exist, and manager training focused on one skill above all: noticing that someone is struggling and knowing what to do next.

The measurement that matters is not how many wellness emails were sent but whether people use the support, whether they feel able to raise a problem before it becomes a leave, and whether workloads are survivable. Those are answerable questions, and the organizations asking them are the ones treating mental health as part of how work is organized rather than as an amenity bolted on the side.

KEY POINTS

- Hybrid work removed stressors like the commute and rigid hours but blurred work-home boundaries and reduced manager visibility.
- Employers that adapt well are explicit about hours, response times and camera norms, and protect focus time from after-hours creep.
- Mental-health support works best when it is routine and easy to reach — real counselling coverage, short waits, memorable assistance programs.
- Manager training should centre on one skill: noticing someone is struggling and knowing what to do next.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Move from perks to structure: set clear expectations, make counselling easy to reach, train managers to spot strain, and measure whether people raise problems before they become leaves.

BUSINESS LINK PODCAST

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About the Podcast

The Business Link AI-Powered Podcast explores the ideas, people, and events shaping our regional business community. Using AI-driven commentary, each episode reviews key business developments, industry trends, and highlights leaders making an impact across the region.

Rather than traditional interviews, the podcast provides insightful overviews and perspectives on business news, events, and initiatives featured across Business Link Media platforms.

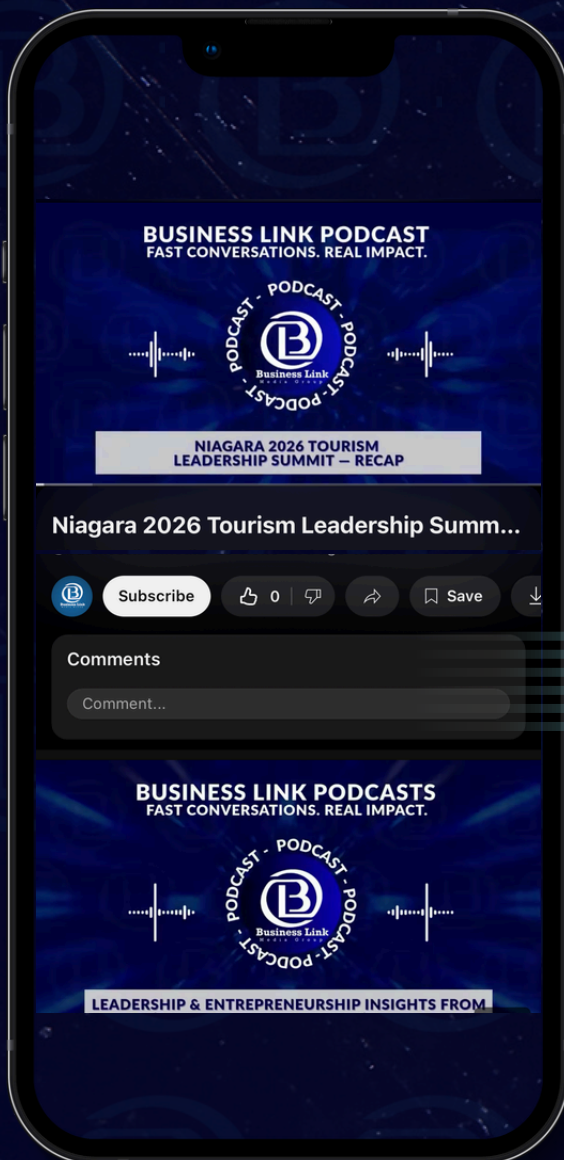
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FINANCE & GROWTH

Financial Resilience in a Higher-for-Longer World

Interest rates have come down from their peak but remain well above the levels a generation of business owners grew up with. A practical playbook for the quarter ahead.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

For roughly fifteen years, cheap money was the background condition of Canadian business. Borrowing was inexpensive, refinancing was routine, and a marginal project often cleared the bar simply because capital cost so little. That era ended, and while rates have eased from their highs, the sensible planning assumption for the next few years is that money will cost meaningfully more than it did in the 2010s. Resilience is the discipline of building a business that does well in that environment rather than one that merely survives it.

Start with visibility. The single most valuable financial tool for a small or mid-sized business is a rolling thirteen-week cash-flow forecast that is updated weekly. It is not sophisticated, and it is not optional. It tells you when cash will be tight before it is tight, which turns a potential crisis into a scheduling problem. Owners who run this discipline consistently report that it changes how they negotiate with customers and suppliers because they can see the consequences of terms in advance.

Next, address debt structure before you address anything else. Map every facility: balance, rate, whether it is fixed or variable, when it renews and what covenants apply. Concentrate on two risks — facilities that renew within

twelve months, and variable-rate exposure large enough that a further rate move would strain the business. Talk to your lender early about extending terms, converting to fixed, or consolidating. Lenders strongly prefer a conversation six months ahead of a problem to a surprise at renewal.

Protect margin deliberately. In a higher-cost environment, the businesses that hold up are the ones that have re-examined pricing, shed unprofitable customers and products, and kept a close eye on the input costs that move most. Many owners discover, when they finally run the numbers by customer and by line, that a meaningful share of revenue is being served at little or no profit. Fixing that is usually faster and more certain than chasing new sales.

Build a real reserve. A cash buffer sized to cover several months of fixed costs is expensive to hold and invaluable to have. If building it from operations is slow, an undrawn line of credit arranged while the business is healthy serves a similar purpose — but arrange it before you need it, because credit is hardest to get at the moment you most want it.

“A rolling thirteen-week cash-flow forecast, updated weekly, turns a potential crisis into a scheduling problem. It is not optional.”

FINANCE & GROWTH

Financial Resilience in a Higher-for-Longer World — continued

Be selective with growth. Higher capital costs raise the bar a project must clear. That is not a reason to stop investing; it is a reason to insist that each investment has a clear, near-term payback and a plan for what happens if it underperforms. Staged commitments — spending in tranches tied to milestones — keep you from being fully exposed to a bet that goes wrong.

Finally, diversify the things that can concentrate risk: a single dominant customer, one key supplier, one lender, one currency. None of these needs to be solved overnight, but each should be on a list with a direction of travel.

It is worth stress-testing the plan against a bad quarter. Pick a realistic shock — your largest customer delays payment by sixty days, or sales fall fifteen per cent for three months — and walk it through the thirteen-week forecast. The exercise usually surfaces one or two specific

vulnerabilities that can be fixed cheaply now: a supplier term renegotiated, a standby facility arranged, a discretionary cost made variable instead of fixed.

Communication matters more than owners expect. Lenders, key suppliers and landlords all respond better to a business that brings them a plan early than one that goes quiet and then asks for help. A short quarterly update to your banker — here is how the year is tracking, here is what we are watching — costs nothing and builds the credibility you will want to draw on if you ever need flexibility.

None of this is dramatic. Resilience rarely is. It is a series of unglamorous decisions — forecast weekly, fix the debt calendar, defend margin, hold a buffer, stage your bets — that together let a business treat a difficult rate environment as weather rather than emergency.

KEY POINTS

- Plan on money costing meaningfully more than it did in the 2010s, and build a business that does well in that environment.
- Map every facility — balance, rate, renewal, covenants — and act early on anything renewing within twelve months.
- Re-run pricing by customer and product; a surprising share of revenue is often served at little or no profit.
- Arrange a standby line while the business is healthy, and stress-test the plan against a sixty-day payment delay from your largest customer.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Forecast cash weekly, fix the debt-renewal calendar, defend margin customer by customer, hold a real reserve, and stage your growth bets. Resilience is a series of unglamorous decisions made on time.

FINANCE & GROWTH

The Bank of Canada and Your Operating Line

You cannot forecast the central bank. You can make sure its next move is not the thing that decides your year.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

“Watch your covenants as closely as your rate. Many tighten automatically as interest costs rise, even if sales are steady.”

The Bank of Canada sets the overnight rate, and most business operating lines and variable loans are priced off the prime rate that moves with it. When commentators debate whether the next change is a cut, a hold or a hike, what they are really debating is the monthly cost of every dollar you have drawn on that line.

The useful response is not prediction but preparation. Know your number: how much are you drawing on average, and what would a further quarter-point or half-point move add to your monthly interest cost? For many businesses the figure is smaller than feared; for some it is large enough to matter, and those are the businesses that should act.

If your variable exposure is significant, ask your lender about options: converting part of the balance to a fixed-rate term loan, extending amortization to lower the monthly payment, or blending facilities. Each has a cost,

and the point of asking now is to make the choice on your terms rather than under pressure.

Watch your covenants as closely as your rate. Many facilities carry conditions — a minimum ratio of earnings to debt payments, a working-capital floor — that tighten automatically as interest costs rise, even if your sales are steady. Model where you stand against each covenant under a modestly worse rate scenario, and if you are close, raise it with your lender before the quarter closes rather than after.

The operating line is meant to smooth the timing gap between paying suppliers and collecting from customers. When it is instead financing losses or funding long-term assets, rate moves stop being a nuisance and become a threat. The quarter ahead is a good time to make sure the line is doing the job it was designed for.

KEY POINTS

- Operating lines and variable loans move with the Bank of Canada's overnight rate through prime.
- Know your number: the average balance drawn and what a quarter- or half-point move adds to monthly interest.
- If variable exposure is significant, ask about converting to fixed, extending amortization or blending facilities — on your terms.
- Covenants can tighten automatically as rates rise; model each one under a worse scenario and raise concerns early.

THE BOTTOM LINE

You cannot predict the central bank, so prepare instead: size your exposure, fix or restructure it before you have to, watch covenants as closely as the rate, and keep the operating line doing the job it was designed for.

SEPTEMBER 15 - OCTOBER 15

Events

IN THE NIAGARA REGION

75th Niagara Grape & Wine Festival – Discovery Pass Weekends

September 18 – 20 & 25 – 27, 2026

Wine country & Montebello Park, St. Catharines
niagarawinefestival.com

Niagara 5000 – Supercars & Aviation Showcase

September 18 – 19, 2026

Niagara Falls & Niagara District Airport
niagara5000.com

Misty City Music Festival

September 18 – 20, 2026

Niagara Falls, ON
mistycityfestival.com

Grande Parade – 75th Niagara Grape & Wine Festival

September 26, 2026

Downtown St. Catharines
niagarawinefestival.com/grande-parade

GNCC Business After 5 – October

October 6, 2026 · 5:00 – 7:00 pm

Greater Niagara Chamber of Commerce (rotating host venue)
gncc.ca/events

Canadian Greenhouse Conference & Tradeshow 2026

October 7 – 8, 2026

Scotiabank Convention Centre, Niagara Falls
canadiangreenhouseconference.com

Dates and details are compiled from public event calendars (Greater Niagara Chamber of Commerce, Niagara Falls / Scotiabank Convention Centre, Destination Niagara and organizer sites) and are subject to change. Confirm with organizers before attending.



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INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY

Small-Business Cybersecurity: A Practical Guide for Growing Companies

Attackers do not skip small businesses — they prefer them. A short list of measures delivers most of the protection, and none of it requires a large budget.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

There is a persistent myth among small-business owners that they are too small to be a target. The opposite is true. Automated attacks do not distinguish by company size, and criminals have learned that small firms often hold valuable data and money while running far weaker defences than large enterprises. The good news is that the measures that stop the large majority of attacks are well understood, inexpensive and within reach of any organization willing to spend a few focused weeks on them.

Begin with identity, because stolen or guessed passwords are behind most breaches. Turn on multi-factor authentication everywhere it is available — email first, then banking, accounting, remote access and any system holding customer data. Give every employee their own account, remove accounts the day someone leaves, and use a password manager so that people are not reusing the same weak password across a dozen services. This single category of change closes the most common door.

Keep software current. The vulnerabilities used in real attacks are usually ones that were patched months earlier by the vendor and never installed by the victim. Turn on automatic updates for operating systems, browsers, phones and business applications. Replace equipment that no longer receives security updates; an unpatched

device on your network is a liability regardless of how well it still runs.

Back up your data, and make at least one copy that an attacker cannot reach from your network — an offline drive or a separate cloud account with its own credentials. Ransomware is survivable if you can restore. Test a restore at least once so you learn the process before an emergency rather than during one.

Train the people. Most incidents start with a convincing email that persuades someone to click a link, open a file or change payment details. A short, plain session every quarter — here is what a current scam looks like, here is how to verify a request to move money, here is who to tell if you are unsure — measurably reduces the success rate. Make it safe to report a mistake quickly; the cost of a reported click is far lower than a hidden one.

Protect the money specifically. Require a second person to approve payments above a set threshold and any change to a supplier's banking details. Verify such changes by phoning a known number, never by replying to the email that requested them. Business email compromise — an invoice redirected to a criminal's account — is one of the costliest attacks facing Canadian firms, and this one control blocks most of it.

“Automated attacks do not distinguish by company size. Criminals have learned that small firms hold value while running far weaker defences.”

INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY

Small-Business Cybersecurity: A Practical Guide — continued

Write down a short response plan. One page: who to call, how to isolate an affected machine, where the backups are, which regulators or partners must be notified, and how you will operate manually for a day or two. The Canadian Centre for Cyber Security publishes free, practical baseline guidance for small and medium organizations that maps closely to this list.

Cyber-insurance has become a useful forcing function even for businesses that never file a claim. Insurers now ask applicants to confirm the basics — multi-factor authentication, backups, patching, employee training — and pricing reflects the answers. Treat the application questionnaire as a free checklist: if you cannot answer yes to an item, that is the next thing to fix.

None of this needs to happen at once. A realistic plan is to spend one focused week on identity and multi-factor authentication, a second on backups and patching, and a recurring half-day each quarter on training and the payment controls. Within a couple of months a small business can move from largely exposed to genuinely difficult to attack — which, for a criminal choosing targets by ease, is usually enough.

Finally, extend the questions to your vendors. Your accounting platform, your point-of-sale provider and your managed IT supplier all hold or touch your data. Ask what happens to your information if they are breached, and make sure your contracts and your cyber-insurance expectations line up with their answers.

KEY POINTS

- Identity first: multi-factor authentication on email, banking and remote access closes the most common door.
- Business email compromise is among the costliest attacks; verify any change of payment details by phone, never by reply.
- Keep an offline backup an attacker cannot reach — and test a restore before you need one.
- The Canadian Centre for Cyber Security publishes free baseline controls for small and medium organizations.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Turn on multi-factor authentication everywhere, keep software patched, hold an offline backup you have tested, train the team quarterly, and require phone verification for any change to payment details.

FINANCE & GROWTH

Five Metrics to Watch Heading Into Year-End

A short dashboard that tells an owner more about the health of the business than the income statement alone.

SOURCE: BUSINESS LINK MEDIA GROUP

1. Thirteen-week cash forecast. Not a metric in the traditional sense, but the one number that prevents surprises. Updated weekly, it shows the lowest projected cash balance over the next quarter and the week it occurs. If that low point is uncomfortably close to zero, every other decision changes.

2. Days sales outstanding. The average number of days it takes to collect an invoice. A rising trend means your customers are financing themselves with your money. Watching it weekly, and acting on the oldest accounts first, is often the fastest way to free up cash without borrowing.

3. Gross margin by customer and product. The blended margin on the income statement hides a wide range. Rank customers and products by the actual margin each contributes. The bottom of that list — the revenue served

at little or no profit — is usually where the easiest year-end improvements live.

4. Fixed-cost coverage. How many months could the business pay its fixed costs from cash on hand plus committed, undrawn credit, with no new sales? This is the single best summary of resilience, and it is the number a lender will look at first.

5. Revenue concentration. The share of revenue that comes from your largest customer, and from your top five. If the largest is above roughly a fifth of the total, a plan to broaden the base belongs in the 2027 objectives — not because the customer is going anywhere, but because the risk is worth managing before it matters. None of these requires new software. A spreadsheet updated on the same day each week is enough.

THE BOTTOM LINE

Reviewed together once a month, these five numbers take about half an hour and give a far clearer read on the quarter ahead than year-end statements that arrive after the decisions were due.

Sources, Further Reading & Contributors

The features in this issue are original editorial prepared by Business Link Media Group. The organizations and publications below are recommended for readers who want to go deeper on the topics covered, and were used as general background for the reporting.

BUSINESS & ECONOMY

- Statistics Canada — Canadian Survey on Business Conditions (statcan.gc.ca)
- Business Development Bank of Canada — economic research and owner resources (bdc.ca)
- Ontario Chamber of Commerce — Ontario Economic Report (occ.ca)
- Greater Niagara Chamber of Commerce (gncc.ca)

TECHNOLOGY

- Canadian Centre for Cyber Security — Baseline Cyber Security Controls for Small and Medium Organizations (cyber.gc.ca)
- Get Cyber Safe — Government of Canada public awareness program (getcybersafe.gc.ca)
- Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada — AI and digital adoption programs (ised-isde.canada.ca)

HEALTH & WORKFORCE

- Public Health Agency of Canada — chronic disease and prevention data (canada.ca/public-health)
- Canadian Centre for Occupational Health and Safety — workplace mental health resources (ccohs.ca)
- Mental Health Commission of Canada — National Standard for Psychological Health and Safety in the Workplace (mentalhealthcommission.ca)

FINANCE

- Bank of Canada — interest rate announcements and the Monetary Policy Report (bankofcanada.ca)
- Canada Revenue Agency — year-end and small-business tax guidance (canada.ca/cra)
- BDC — cash-flow planning tools and templates (bdc.ca)

EVENTS

- Destination Niagara — regional event calendar
- Niagara Falls (Scotiabank) Convention Centre — event listings
- Niagara Grape & Wine Festival; Clifton Hill Niagara Falls event guide

COLOPHON

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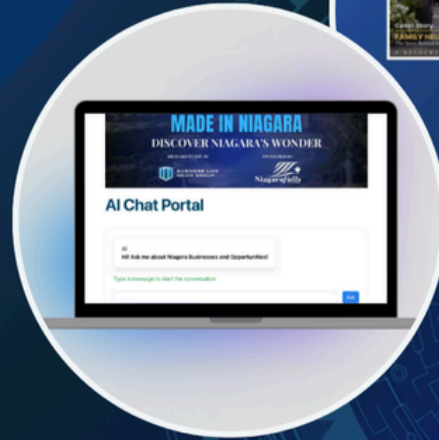
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